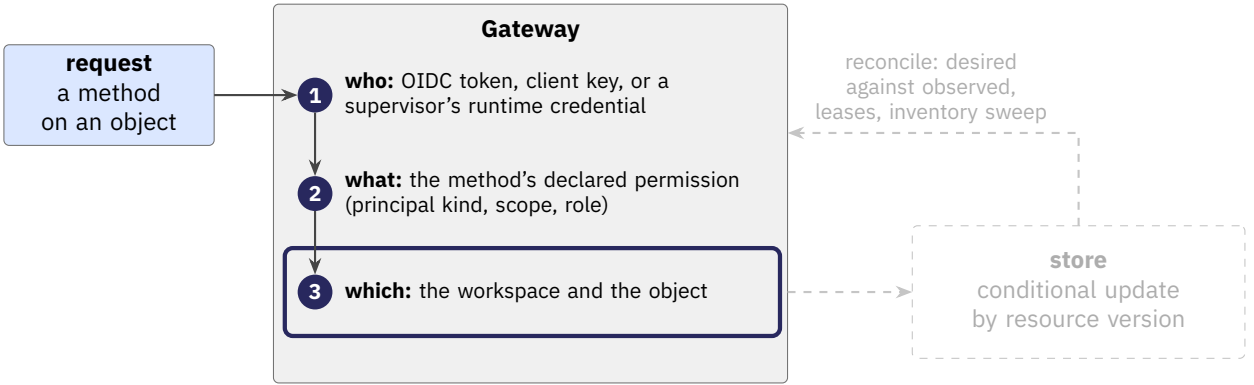a request to the gateway